COPENHAGEN, DENMARK

Statens Museum for Kunst: Masterpieces

Twenty works at SMK, from a tavern encounter to an empty studio and a face divided by green.



A man turns toward the viewer in Carl Bloch's tavern, as though someone has approached the table. In Hammershøi's room, a woman's face remains turned away. These two pictures offer different kinds of access: one produces an encounter, the other gives the room more freely than it gives its inhabitant.

This selection from Copenhagen's SMK follows such differences in looking. Artists examine sketches, clouds and ships under construction; Matisse and Derain ask how strongly colour can change while a face or body remains legible. The twenty works connect through those problems rather than through a single period. Some make observation their subject, while others make the viewer's own position unusually noticeable.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/statens-museum-kunst

The selection · 20

1. In a Roman Osteria
   Carl Bloch · 1866
2. The Fall of the Titans
   Cornelis van Haarlem · 1588-1590
3. Portrait of Madame Matisse: The Green Line
   Henri Matisse · 1905
4. Pierrot
   Amedeo Modigliani · 1915
5. Portrait of a Man
   El Greco · 1575
6. The Wounded Philoctetes
   Nicolai Abildgaard · 1775
7. A Group of Danish Artists in Rome
   Constantin Hansen · 1837
8. View of the Interior of the Colosseum
   Christoffer Wilhelm Eckersberg · 1816
9. View from Dosseringen towards Nørrebro
   Christen Købke · 1838
10. A Room in Strandgade with the Artist's Wife
    Vilhelm Hammershøi · 1901
11. Interior with the Artist's Easel
    Vilhelm Hammershøi · 1910
12. Woman in a Chemise
    André Derain · 1906
13. The Ryberg Family
    Jens Juel · c. 1793-1797
14. Ditlev Blunck Examining a Sketch in a Mirror
    Wilhelm Bendz · 1826
15. Interior with a Violin
    Henri Matisse · 1918
16. Concert: The Artist's Children and Their Playmates
    Otto Haslund · 1887
17. A Charlatan Selling Blacking in Piazza Barberini
    Wilhelm Marstrand · 1840-1849
18. Cloudscape, Study
    Christoffer Wilhelm Eckersberg · 1826
19. A Corvette on the Stocks, Copenhagen
    Christoffer Wilhelm Eckersberg · 1828
20. A Blind Man outside His House
    Michael Ancher · c. 1881-1884

01 / 20

In a Roman Osteria

Carl Bloch

1866 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Carl Bloch. In a Roman Osteria. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The turned head makes the table's company aware of a presence outside the picture. Its near edge brings that encounter close, while other diners continue farther back in the darker room. Bloch gives the scene an implied interruption without showing who has arrived. The viewer occupies the position from which that interruption seems to come.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS4087

02 / 20

The Fall of the Titans

Cornelis van Haarlem

1588-1590 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Cornelis van Haarlem. The Fall of the Titans. Statens Museum for Kunst, Copenhagen. Public domain; compressed study reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The bodies turn in opposing directions, making it difficult to locate a stable position within the fall. Rocks provide points of contact but little security. The mythological defeat also becomes a display of the body's possible twists and extensions, with anatomy supplying the principal means through which collective disaster is made visible.

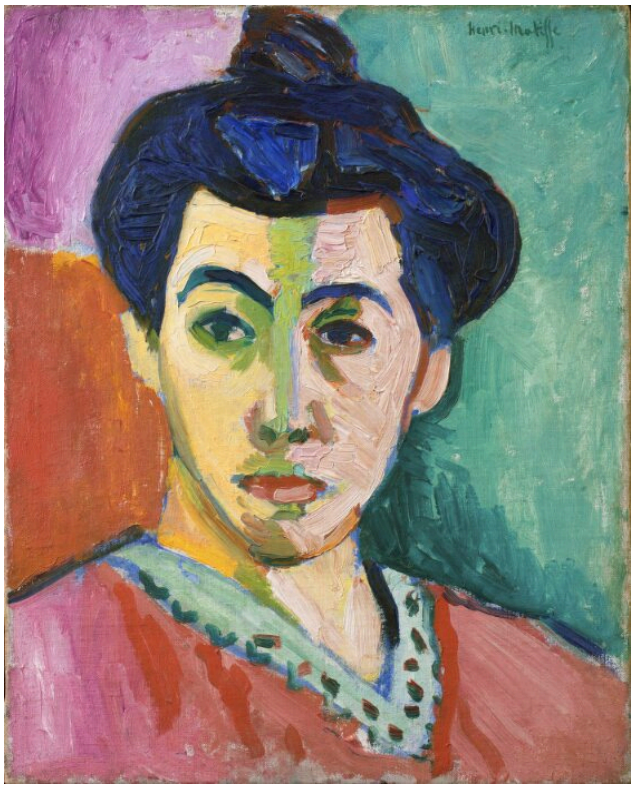
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS1

03 / 20

Portrait of Madame Matisse: The Green Line

Henri Matisse

1905 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Henri Matisse. Portrait of Madame Matisse. The Green Line. SMK, Copenhagen. Public Domain Mark 1.0; compressed study reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The green band divides the face into differently coloured halves without preventing recognition of Amélie Matisse. Its force comes from contrast rather than naturalistic flesh tones. This is also a small painting, about 40.5 by 32.5 centimetres: the emphatic colour gives it a presence that a screen reproduction can easily confuse with physical scale.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMSr171

04 / 20

Pierrot

Amedeo Modigliani

1915 · Oil on cardboard · Statens Museum for Kunst



Pierrot (Self Portrait as Pierrot). WikiArt; Amedeo Modigliani. Proportional resizing and JPEG compression; source frame preserved. · Public domain

The ruff and angular headwear identify a theatrical role, while the long face is assembled from narrow features and greenish areas. The figure remains human despite its mask-like presentation. Costume therefore provides more than a topic: it allows a portrait-like image to test how far a face can be simplified and still register as a person.

Object source · Open artwork

05 / 20

Portrait of a Man

El Greco

1575 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



El Greco. Portrait of a man (Andrea Palladio). WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/el-greco/portrait-of-a-man-andrea-palladio-1575 · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The pale hand extends beyond the compact dark clothing, giving the portrait an action outside the face. Cuffs and beard remain distinct against the subdued setting. The sitter has sometimes been identified as Palladio, but that name is disputed. The gesture and likeness can be described without turning the proposed identity into a certainty.

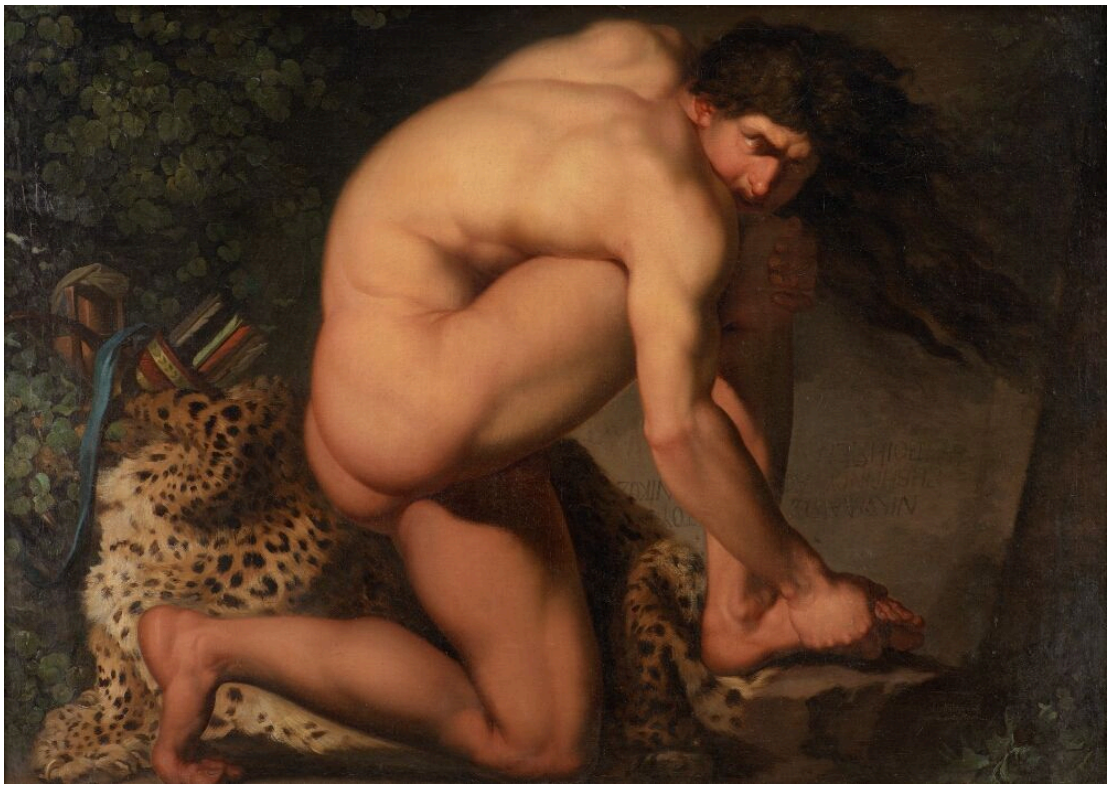
Object source · Open artwork

06 / 20

The Wounded Philoctetes

Nicolai Abildgaard

1775 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Nicolai Abildgaard. The Wounded Philoctetes. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Both hands draw attention toward the injured foot, while the back and limbs fold around it. Pain becomes an organisation of the whole body rather than something confined to an expression. The figure's isolation makes the act of holding the wound particularly clear: there is no surrounding group to distribute the scene's weight.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS586

07 / 20

A Group of Danish Artists in Rome

Constantin Hansen

1837 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Constantin Hansen. A Group of Danish Artists in Rome. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The men share a room without sharing a single action. Sitting, standing and turning in different directions gives artistic company the appearance of ongoing occupation rather than a ceremonial assembly. Individual likenesses remain part of a collective portrait, and the open view beyond prevents the room from becoming an entirely sealed professional world.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS3236

08 / 20

View of the Interior of the Colosseum

Christoffer Wilhelm Eckersberg

1816 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Christoffer Wilhelm Eckersberg. View of the Interior of the Colosseum. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Arches and broken walls remain parts of a structure whose distances can be followed. The small figures establish a bodily scale without turning the ruin into a setting for a major incident. Eckersberg's account depends on intervals and changing planes, allowing the building's organisation to survive alongside its visible incompleteness.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS1776

09 / 20

View from Dosseringen towards Nørrebro

Christen Købke

1838 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Christen Købke. A View from Dosseringen near the Sortedam Lake Looking Towards Nørrebro. SMK, Copenhagen. Public Domain Mark 1.0; compressed study reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The flagpole sets one firm vertical against the broad horizontal continuity of water and sky. Two nearby figures and a distant boat occupy only a small part of that extent. The result is a landscape in which ordinary activity has room without having to become the principal measure of everything around it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS359

10 / 20

A Room in Strandgade with the Artist’s Wife

Vilhelm Hammershøi

1901 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Vilhelm Hammershøi. A Room in the Artist's Home in Strandgade, Copenhagen, with the Artist's Wife. SMK, Copenhagen. Public Domain Mark 1.0; compressed study reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The woman's face is withheld, while the room's boundaries remain unusually clear. A small grid of sunlight gives the floor a localised event within the larger stillness. The contrast matters: the painting offers precise information about space without offering equivalent access to the person occupying it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS3696

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Interior with the Artist’s Easel

Vilhelm Hammershøi

1910 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Vilhelm Hammershøi. Interior with the Artist’s Easel. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

An easel and a framed picture identify a working space, yet the artist is absent. The open doorway extends the room into another area without introducing visible activity. The arrangement allows painting to become the subject through its equipment and conditions: a place for looking and making remains even when neither is being performed.

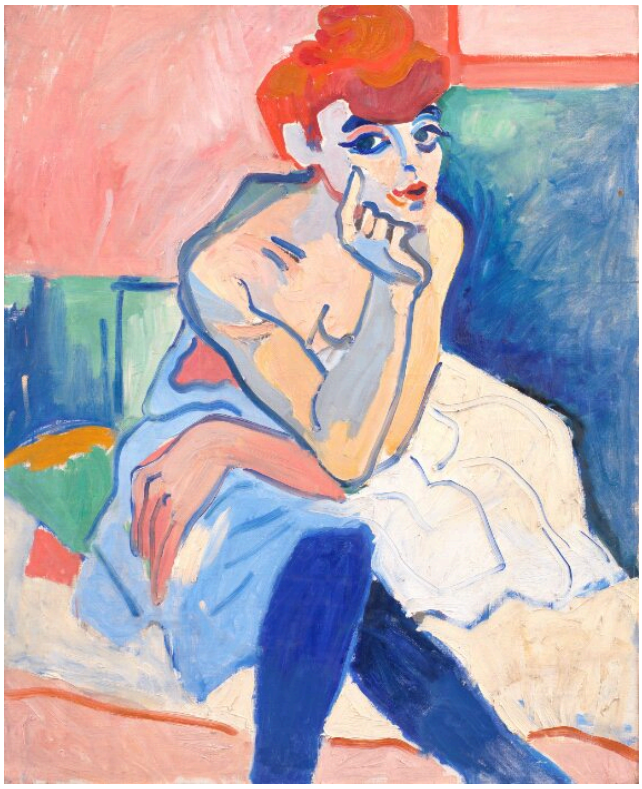
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS7444

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Woman in a Chemise

André Derain

1906 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



André Derain. Woman in a Chemise. Statens Museum for Kunst, Copenhagen. Public domain; compressed study reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The familiar pose—chin supported by a hand—keeps the body legible while pink, blue and green disrupt ordinary distinctions between skin, fabric and shadow. Colour does structural work instead of merely filling an outline. Seen beside Matisse's portrait, the painting offers another way to preserve a figure while changing the hues through which it is recognised.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMSr14

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The Ryberg Family

Jens Juel

c. 1793-1797 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Jens Juel. The Ryberg Family. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Gestures link the seated older man with the standing pair, while the landscape gives their family grouping a wider social setting. The distant view is not incidental scenery: it extends their presentation beyond the immediate foreground. The portrait's claim to position therefore depends on land and surroundings as well as likeness.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS2098

14 / 20

Ditlev Blunck Examining a Sketch in a Mirror

Wilhelm Bendz

1826 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Wilhelm Bendz. En ung kunstner (Ditlev Blunck) betragter en skitse i et spejl. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The mirror supplies another view of the sketch, making judgment visible as a practical change of vantage point. Tools and canvases crowd around the painter, locating that act within a working room. The image shows looking as part of making: the artist pauses to assess what another orientation may reveal.

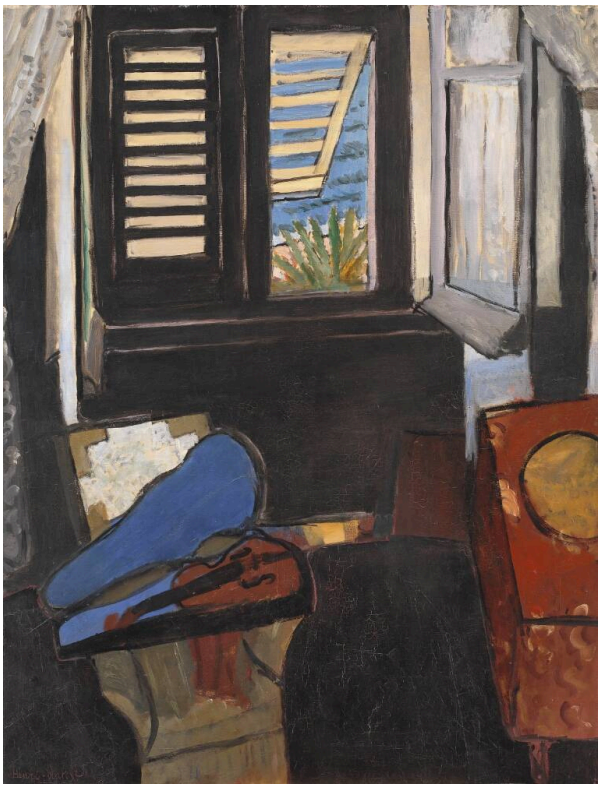
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS280

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Interior with a Violin

Henri Matisse

1918 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Henri Matisse. Interior with a Violin. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The resting violin gives the interior a sign of use without requiring a musician. Open shutters connect the room to a brighter outside, while dark frames divide its adjoining areas. The instrument and furniture participate in the colour arrangement, so a familiar object can hold attention without becoming the centre of a narrative.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMSr83

16 / 20

Concert: The Artist’s Children and Their Playmates

Otto Haslund

1887 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Otto Haslund. "Koncert". Kunstnerens børn og deres legekammerater. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The children bring different kinds of attention to the piano. Some concentrate; others, including the youngest figures, interrupt the idea of a perfectly coordinated concert. That variety makes the gathering more specific than an emblem of domestic harmony. The performance includes the uneven participation that comes with sharing a room across ages.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS1306

17 / 20

A Charlatan Selling Blacking in Piazza Barberini

Wilhelm Marstrand

1840-1849 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Wilhelm Marstrand. A Charlatan Selling Blacking in the Piazza Barberini in Rome. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The seller's demonstration gathers an audience, making persuasion the activity that joins the figures. Their differing responses matter as much as his gesture. Buildings and fountain locate the event in a Roman square, but the commercial performance supplies the closer structure: attention must be won before a sale can be made.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS3770

18 / 20

Cloudscape, Study

Christoffer Wilhelm Eckersberg

1826 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Christoffer Wilhelm Eckersberg. A Cloudscape. Study. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Only a narrow band of ground anchors the cloud layers. The sky must therefore be differentiated internally, through heavier masses and paler openings, rather than treated as one general background. As a study, the picture gives changing atmospheric forms sustained attention without needing a more prominent subject beneath them.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS6433

19 / 20

A Corvette on the Stocks, Copenhagen

Christoffer Wilhelm Eckersberg

1828 · Oil on canvas · Statens Museum for Kunst



Christoffer Wilhelm Eckersberg. A Corvette on the Stocks. Copenhagen. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

Raised on wooden supports, the hull reveals surfaces that water would normally conceal. The ship is shown under the conditions that make it possible, before the familiar image of a vessel afloat. The framework is consequently essential rather than an obstruction: it explains the physical relation between this large structure and the ground.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS6439

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A Blind Man outside His House

Michael Ancher

c. 1881-1884 · Oil on panel · Statens Museum for Kunst



Michael Ancher. A Blind Man Outside his House. Statens Museum for Kunst. Public Domain Mark 1.0. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · Public Domain Mark 1.0

The man's lowered head and supported stance locate him beside the building, while bright light extends over the surrounding ground. The title identifies blindness, but it need not become an explanation of his whole presence. The portrait-like attention to posture gives him a place within the landscape rather than reducing him to a contrast with its visibility.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: KMS3459

Change the distance

Compare a whole composition with a closer view of one detail, keeping the object's dimensions in mind. The effect of Matisse's small portrait differs from that of a large scene of tumbling bodies. SMK's catalogue provides useful object records; current display and visiting arrangements should be checked separately.

Further reading

Concerning the Spiritual in Art

Wassily Kandinsky; translated by Michael Sadleir · Read free · English

Kandinsky’s argument about colour gives a historical companion to the Matisse and Derain paintings. His claims are one artist’s position, not a formula for interpreting the older portraits or Hammershøi’s interiors.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12
